

You may wish to start conservatively, with room to wriggle. I began on \$200 a week, with the option to go up to \$350 if I knew I would need to catch a cab, buy a birthday present or go to the doctor. I was launching from a low base and wanted to see the balance grow quickly, for encouragement, so I preferred to start at the frugal end.

Week 3

This is your time for trial and error, when you nominate your financial gatekeeper – in my case, Mum and Dad.

Withdraw your pocket money in cash but retain access to the salary this week, just in case you break the rules. If you have miscalculated how much pocket money you need, you'll get caught in awkward positions, usually red-faced at a cash register. Heartbreak leads to failure.

Week 4

If you've been successful so far, ask your gatekeeper to open an account in their name, in which your salary will be deposited. Change over your direct debit details to this account for rent and bills. You'll also need a low-fee, everyday debit account – mine is with ANZ – into which your gatekeeper will transfer your weekly pocket money.

When it comes to pocket money transfers from your gatekeeper, be mindful these might take 24 hours to process. Early on, I was caught short several times with a transfer that was made on a Friday but didn't clear in my account until Tuesday. The upside of the delay is that you become more aware of what you are spending; enduring 24 hours before you access the money is motivation for planning ahead, and provides breathing room to consider if any purchases you have been pondering are really necessary.